

BUSINESS FOUNDATION

Business Startup & Formation Workbook

Organize the decisions, records, registrations, systems, and launch priorities behind a new business.

The best business foundation is not only a good idea. It is a clear picture of what the business is, who it serves, what it needs to operate, and who controls the important records and decisions.

Business concept

Planning field	Current answer
Proposed legal name	
DBA / alternate name	
Brand name	
Product or service	
Target customer	
Primary business purpose	
State of formation / operating location	
Planned launch date	

What problem does this business solve?

Legal name vs brand name

A legal name, DBA, and brand name may all be different. Each can matter for registrations, contracts, tax records, and customer-facing communications.

Customer snapshot

Question	Current answer
Who is most likely to buy?	
What problem are they trying to solve?	
How will they find the business?	
How will they pay?	
What makes this business easy to trust?	

Revenue model

Revenue source	One-time / recurring / mixed	Typical payment method	Notes
Primary revenue source			
Secondary revenue source			
Typical transaction flow			
Customer follow-up process			

Initial business goals

First 90 days

First year

Immediate priorities

Ownership and structure

The structure of ownership, control, responsibility, and decision-making matters early because it affects access, authority, tax treatment, and future complexity. Use this page to identify who can do what before the business becomes more established.

Ownership

Owner / member	Ownership %	Role	Decision authority	Initial contribution or responsibility

Management and responsibility

Who handles day-to-day decisions and follow-up?

Who can sign agreements and make financial decisions?

Who manages records and recurring compliance?

Who can access banking, domains, software, and important accounts?

Questions that should be clear early

- | | |
|--------------------------|---|
| ☐ | Who can enter agreements on behalf of the business? |
| ☐ | Who can approve payments or reimbursements? |
| ☐ | Who can hire contractors or employees? |
| ☐ | Who can access banking, domain, and software accounts? |
| ☐ | Who can approve major purchases or refunds? |
| ☐ | Who owns the operational follow-up when the founder is unavailable? |

Professional review

Some ownership and legal decisions affect rights, taxes, liability, or formal authority. Use this workbook to identify the questions and the information each professional will need.

Registration and identity

This page helps organize the administrative foundation that often gets postponed until after the business starts. The goal is to know what is required, where it lives, and who owns the follow-up.

Registration calendar

Requirement to investigate	Agency / jurisdiction	Initial filing	Renewal frequency	Next due date	Owner
State formation filing					
EIN or tax registration					
DBA / assumed name					
Local or industry registration					
Licenses, permits, certificates					
Other jurisdictional requirement					

Formation and identity records

- ☐ Approved formation documents and EIN confirmation
- ☐ Ownership or operating agreement, if applicable
- ☐ Registration confirmations, licenses, and permits
- ☐ Beneficial ownership, registered-agent, or tax-registration information
- ☐ Business email, domain, and contact records

Questions or requirements still to investigate

Formation is not always the final registration step

Depending on the business, there may also be tax registrations, local requirements, insurance requirements, professional licensing, or industry-specific filings. Use the workbook to map the business's actual obligations, not just the first filing.

Where final records live

Record category	Storage location	Backup location	Owner
Formation records			
Ownership / governance records			
Tax and financial records			
Insurance and risk records			
Customer and vendor records			

Financial foundation

A business should not rely on memory or informal cash flow alone. The financial foundation is really a system for where money goes, how records are stored, and who is responsible for review.

Business money rules

- ☐ Business income has a defined destination
- ☐ Business purchases follow a defined payment process
- ☐ Receipts and source records have a defined storage location
- ☐ Owner contributions and reimbursements are easy to trace
- ☐ Deposits and invoice activity are reconciled to the business records
- ☐ Financial access is controlled by the business, not only by a person

Money flow map

Step	System / account	Owner	Review frequency
Customer pays through			
Funds deposit to			
Bookkeeping recorded in			
Expenses paid through			
Receipts stored in			
Monthly review completed by			

Month-end administration

Responsibility	Who does it	How often	Review date	Notes
Reconcile accounts				
Review unpaid invoices				
Categorize unusual transactions				
Store receipts and source documents				
Review processor fees, refunds, and adjustments				
Check upcoming filings or tax deadlines				

Owner activity should be traceable

Owner contributions, reimbursements, personal use, and mixed transactions should not disappear into general business history. A clear record helps later reviews and tax preparation.

Operating and digital foundation

A business can be well-intentioned and still be hard to run if customer-facing and internal systems are disconnected. This page helps identify where work has to be re-done, where records live, and where access is missing.

Customer-facing systems

System	Current choice	Owner	Status	Follow-up
Website				
Domain and email				
Phone / contact path				
Scheduling / forms				
Quotes / estimates				
Payment / invoicing				

Internal systems

System	Current choice	Owner	Status	Follow-up
File storage				
Bookkeeping				
CRM or customer record system				
Project / task management				
Password and access management				
Backups				

Business ownership test

For each critical account, ask:

- ☐ Is the business the account owner?
- ☐ Can more than one authorized person recover it?
- ☐ Is billing controlled by the business?
- ☐ Is MFA enabled where supported?
- ☐ Is the renewal date documented?
- ☐ Could the business continue if the current vendor, contractor, or owner disappeared?

Critical access tracker

System	Recovery contact	Renewal date	Billing owner	Backup person

Launch readiness

The goal is not perfection on day one. The goal is clarity: what is working, what is missing, what must be owned, and what should improve before the business becomes busier.

Readiness dashboard

Category	Not started	In progress	Ready	Professional review
Formation	☐	☐	☐	☐
Finance	☐	☐	☐	☐
Operations	☐	☐	☐	☐
Risk	☐	☐	☐	☐
Digital	☐	☐	☐	☐
Customer experience	☐	☐	☐	☐
Recordkeeping	☐	☐	☐	☐

Commonly overlooked

Domain ownership, renewal dates, contract review, expense separation, backup access, filing calendars, insurance needs, license renewal, record retention, and clear owner responsibilities are commonly missed until a problem appears.

Before first customer

- ☐ Customer inquiry pathway is clear
- ☐ Pricing or quote process is defined
- ☐ Agreement process is in place
- ☐ Payment and invoice process works
- ☐ Customer records have a defined home
- ☐ Follow-up responsibility is assigned

30 / 60 / 90-day plan

Timing	Priority action	Owner	Due date	Status
30 days				
30 days				
60 days				
90 days				

Next step

Need help organizing the foundation? Schedule a consultation at getalchemize.com.

This workbook provides general organizational information, not legal, tax, accounting, licensing, or entity-selection advice. Requirements vary by jurisdiction and circumstance.